

Storytelling and Narratives in Business (BUSN 42124)

Prof. Guy Rolnik

Session 1:

The Power of Stories

How many of you know this clip?

What's the story here?

The story of a Hero's journey

One of the most successful content franchises* of all time.

Estimated at \$47 billion in ~50 years**

* Films, home video, TV series, video games, books, merchandise

** Compared with Pokemon (~\$99Bn), Mickey Mouse & friends (~\$61Bn), Winnie the Pooh (~\$49Bn), Barbie (~\$36Bn), Harry Potter (~\$35Bn), Marvel Cinematic Universe (~\$34Bn)

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Not only because it's Star Wars.
But also because the story,
and others like it, have been
used throughout history –
to inform, to connect, to inspire,
to incite action

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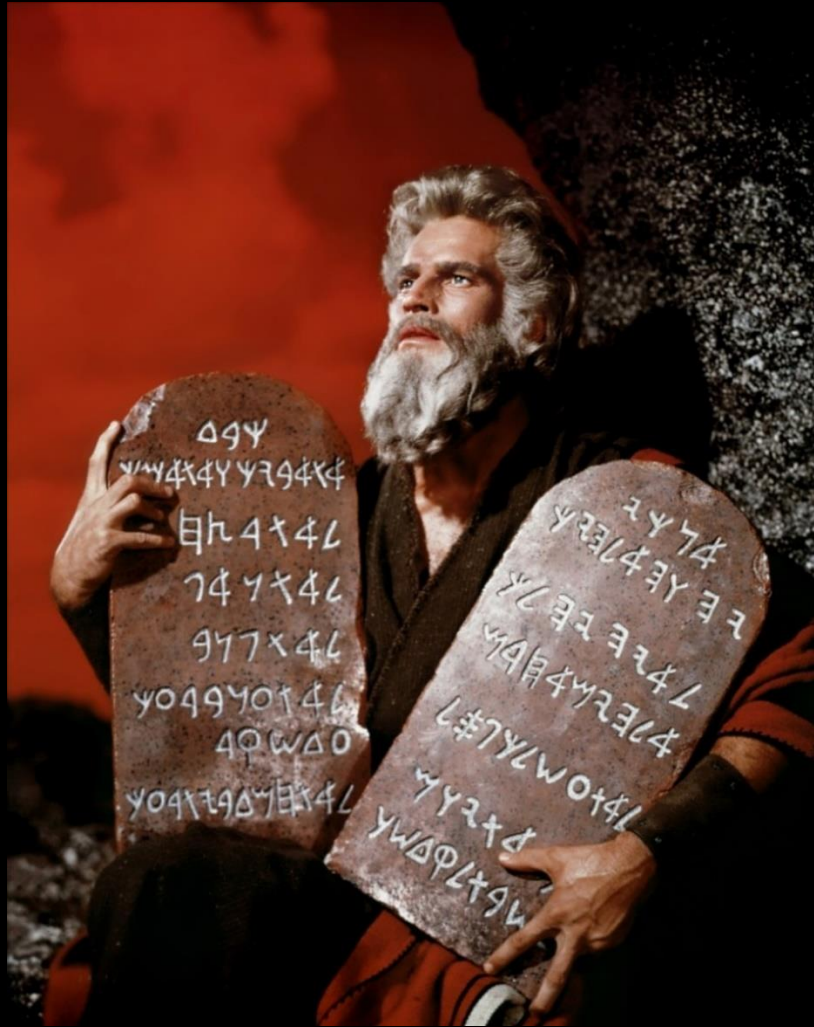
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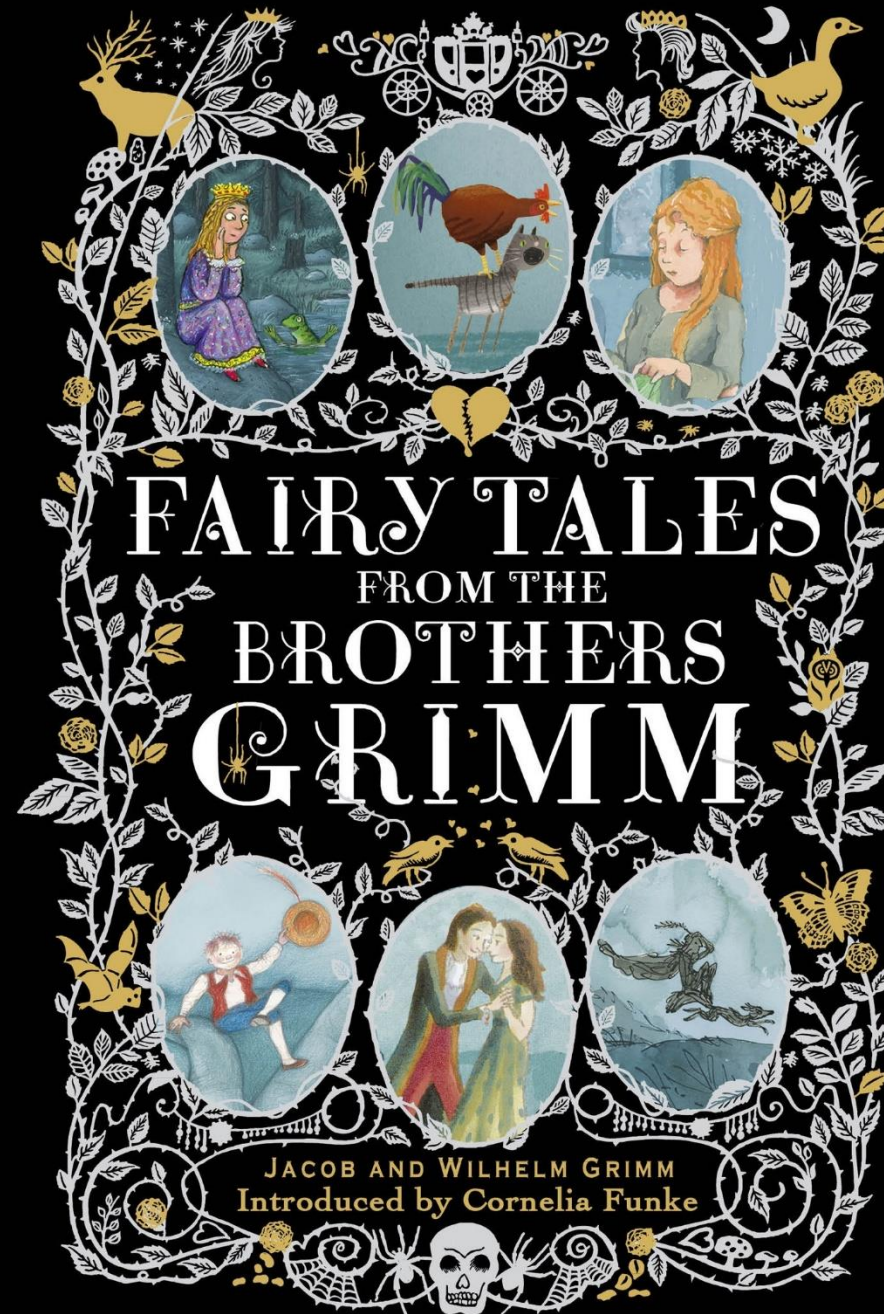
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Throughout history, stories formed the backbone of culture, rules, governance, ideas and behavior.

This is true to this day.

NETFLIX





In this course we will study
the critical role of stories
in life and in business.

In driving success
in many **real-life** situations.

- Interacting with bosses and colleagues
- Leading change within an organization
- Attracting and retaining customers
- Lobbying politicians and regulators
- Influencing the media
- Recruiting employees
- Interviewing for a job
- Raising money for your start up
- Commanding a higher valuation

Have you ever wondered
what's the value of a good story?

What is the economic value of this company?

Selected data from annual reports. All numbers in billion US Dollars.

	2018	2019	2020	2021
Revenue	21.5	24.6	31.5	53.8
Operating income	(0.4)	(0.07)	2	6.5
Net income	(1.0)	(0.9)	0.7	5.5
Operating cash flow	2.1	2.4	5.9	11.5
Total shareholder equity	4.9	6.6	22.2	30.2

~\$1.06Tr



What is the economic value of this company?

Selected data from annual reports. All numbers in billion US Dollars.

	2021	2022	2023	2024
Revenue	53.8	81.5	96.8	97.7
Operating income	6.5	13.8	8.9	7.8
Net income	5.5	12.6	15	7.1
Operating cash flow	11.5	14.7	13.3	14.9
Total shareholder equity	30.2	44.7	62.6	72.9

~\$1.04Tn

What's the story?

Company	Operating income, \$USBn, 2024	Market Cap, \$USBn	Millions of vehicles sold, 2024 [#rank]
Tesla	6.5	927	1.8
Toyota	22.2	252	10.2 [#1]
BYD	38 [2023]	157	4.3 [#7]
Volkswagen	21	59	9 [#2]
BMW Group	14.1	55	2.5 [#10]
GM	11.4	49	6 [#4]
Honda	6.5	45	3.8 [#8]
Ford	10.6	40	4.5 [#6]
Stellantis (FCA + PSA)	16.6	36	5.4 [#5]
Hyundai	5.2	34	7.2 [#3]

What about the P/E ratio?

Company	P/E ratio
BYD	31.5
GM	7.8
Toyota	7.4
Honda	6.8
Ford	6.8
BMW Group	6.8
Stellantis (FCA + PSA)	6
Daimler	5.5
Volkswagen	4.7
Hyundai	3.1

Tesla's P/E ratio?

180

Ok. So maybe the stock market
is evaluating Tesla
as a technology company, right?

Company	P/E ratio
Tesla	180
Nvidia	56
Microsoft	40
Amazon	37
Apple	33
Meta	28
Alphabet	21

In this course we'd like to
achieve the following goals

1. Understand why stories are so fundamental and critical in our lives – to communities and to societies, to politics, religion and science, and of course – to business

2. Understand that much of the world around us, what we most of the time perceive as reality, is actually constructed of stories

3. Learn the patterns, components and principles of most stories: how they are constructed in literature, film, politics, culture and business

4. Learn to tell stories in an impactful way – based on structure and content (regardless of style, language, syntax or humor)

5. Develop an awareness and understanding of how companies craft and control narratives told to their stakeholders – investors, clients, customers, partners, employees, politicians and regulators

6. Most importantly, each one of you will develop **your own business story.**

In short...

- Recognize the stories that make up the world around you
- Understand the machinery behind and the principles of stories
- Become a storyteller

Be a Storyteller

How will we accomplish
those tasks?

The Professor

- Clinical professor, **not** an academic
- **Entrepreneur**, founder of a news media company
 - Documentary **films** creator, writer and director
- **Storyteller**
- 30 years in **media** as financial journalist, Editor-in-Chief
- B.A., MBA, AMP, ALI from TAU, Kellogg, Harvard
- 25 years at the **nexus** of business, regulation and media

Teaching Assistant

Nadia Belkind

- Sociologist and Instructor of Interpersonal Communication Skills
- Head TA since 2019 for EMBA Storytelling and Reputation-Regulation classes for Prof. Rolnik
- Career and Confidence Coach
- Ex-HR in Database Start-Up
- B.A, M.A., Sociology of Higher Education, TAU



Our guest storyteller

Roni Frank



The students:

- A diverse, international group of **curious**, very smart individuals
- Avid consumers of media (even if you don't **acknowledge** that)
- Want to be better entrepreneurs, executives, and citizens
- Want to be smarter, more **sophisticated** consumers, customers and investors
- Want to be better **storytellers**

Rules of our story

All the discussion here is under Chatham House Rules:

When a meeting, or part thereof, is held under the Chatham House Rule, participants are free to use the information received, but neither the identity nor the affiliation of the speaker(s), nor that of any other participant, may be revealed.

The Critical Roles of Confidentiality and Trust

No electronics in class

An electronic device is a wall
between the storyteller and the listener!

If needed, don't hesitate to get in touch with Nadia to discuss
alternative options.

Please also remember to bring
your name tag to all sessions

This class relies on many video clips, so the PowerPoint might occasionally crash.

Please attend with an open
mind and be ready to
challenge your conventions

To get the most out of this
course, you will need to
tell your stories.

Share your stories

Discuss your stories

Course Game Plan

SESSION	TOPIC	DESCRIPTION
1	The Power of Stories Guest Speaker: Roni Frank	Introduction to stories. Typical structures and plots.
2	All Audiences Are Not Created Equal	Defining a story's purpose. Knowing the audience. Defining the story's primary message.
3	There's No Story Without Conflict	Hero, nemesis and conflict. Climax, change and resolution. Setting and inciting event. Pressure point. Stakes.
4	A Story is the Strongest Moat: Warren Buffett's Case Study	Perceptions Vs reality. Choosing your enemies. Managing your story at all times.
5	Elon Musk's Case Study Your Questions Course Summary	The Story of Elon Musk Addressing difficult storytelling situations.

Deliverables

Class Participation – 30%

- Attendance during all five sessions - participation will be tracked in each class based on the quality of the response.
- Telling your story in class.
- Responding to cold calling.
- Reading all required reading materials thoroughly before each class.
- Submitting Memo on Warren Buffett's Case Study.
Due: before session 4
- Participating in two peer feedback meetings in groups of 4 students.
- Submitting one Progress Report after a peer feedback meeting.

Final Project submitted individually – 70%

- Final written version of your personal business story ~ 500-700 words.
- 5-minute video recording of your story, including the version of your story charted across the “Arc Canvas” template provided by Prof. Rolnik
Due - Friday, September 12, 2025, at midnight.

Group meetings and progress reports

The purpose: feedback-based story development

- Experience telling your story
- Experience growth based on feedback
- Practice listening, thereby becoming better storytellers

Groups will meet once during the week at a time convenient to all members and once (optional) after the course is over

- Each member will submit one individual progress report (after session 5 of the class)
- Sign-up spreadsheet and report assignments are live on Canvas

The meetings are a key tool for improving your story:

**a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity
to receive fully supportive, no-pressure, agenda-free feedback.**

Office Hours with Prof. Rolnik and Nadia

During this week, you have a chance to join group office hours:

- To share your story and receive feedback
- To ask questions
- To learn from other student stories
- To evaluate your progress and make improvements towards the finals

The sign-up spreadsheet is live on Canvas.

Once you have signed up, you must attend the session.

Please sign-up today.

Group Office Hours with Prof. Rolnik

Monday, August 11

Tuesday, August 12

Wednesday, August 13

Friday, August 15

Time: 12:30 PM – 2 PM

Max number of students: 5 (not related to your peer group of 4 students)

Location: Booth 455 (across Gleacher) Room 101

One-on-One Office Hours with Nadia Belkind

Monday, August 11

Tuesday, August 12

Wednesday, August 13

Friday, August 15

Time: 12:30 PM – 2 PM

Session length: 20 minutes per session

Location: Booth 455 (across Gleacher) room 132

Additional information is on Canvas.

Once you have signed up, you must attend the session.

Office Hours Rules

- Please sign up for only one session, either an individual or a group one
- Once you register, attendance is mandatory
- Please make sure to mark the session time on your calendar

Peer Feedback Meetings: Groups of 4 students	Group Office Hours with Prof. Rolnik	Individual Office Hours with Nadia Belkind
Conducted by students at the time of their choosing during the week	Conducted by Prof. Rolnik in a group of 5 students who signed up individually	Conducted by Nadia
Prof. Rolnik & Nadia won't join those sessions		
Mandatory one session ~90 minute sessions	Optional ~90 minute sessions	Optional ~20 minute sessions
The second session is highly recommended	Not related to your peer group of 4. You don't need to come as a group.	One-on-One session
Goal: Collaborate with peers for mutual feedback	Goal: Get feedback from the Professor and peers in a small group	Goal: Personalized story development support
Guidelines are on Canvas	Spots are limited	Spots are limited

Questions?

A few more comments
before we dive in

The most important – and **most challenging** part of this course – is finding your story, and **sharing it** with others

Will you be willing to do it?

Why do students find it hard
to share their personal stories?

Storytelling hesitations and fears*

Personal reasons

- I'm not a storyteller
- I don't have the experience
- I've had bad experience in the past, telling my story in public
- I don't have the confidence
- I have social anxiety/ I fear public speaking
- I'm an introvert
- I'm uncomfortable talking about myself
- I'm uncomfortable talking about uncomfortable things
- I'm a perfectionist
- Other students' stories will be better than mine
- **I'll be judged**

Story reasons

- I don't have a story
- I have nothing interesting to tell
- My story is not good
- My story is too long
- My story is too short
- People/The audience might not connect with my story
- People/The audience might not understand my story
- English is not my first language
- Where I come from, it's taboo to tell personal stories
- In the context of business, telling stories is unserious

Personal Reasons (and why they mean
you're exactly where you need to be)

“I’m not a storyteller.”

That’s the point. This class isn’t about showcasing talent — it’s about growth. Everyone starts without the tools. This is where you begin building them. You don’t need to have the skill already — you need the willingness to step into something new.

“I don’t have the experience.”

That makes your story even more powerful. What happens in this class may be the first time you tell your story — and that moment of risk, of crossing a threshold, *is* the story. There’s no experience more authentic than trying for the first time.

“I don’t have the confidence.”

Confidence doesn’t come first. It comes later, after you speak, after you connect, after you survive the unknown and feel heard. That’s why this environment matters. It’s designed so that risk becomes reward.

“I have social anxiety / I fear public speaking.”

This isn't a stage. It's a circle. And fear is not a reason to stay silent — it's the path you walk through to find something new in yourself. Here, pressure doesn't crush you — it reveals what you're capable of.

“I’m an introvert.”

Which often means you’re carrying the richest material. Introverts tend to process deeply, observe precisely, and reveal things others overlook. When you speak, it’s usually worth listening. This is your moment to be heard.

“I’m uncomfortable talking about myself.”

That discomfort? That’s the tension every story needs. It means there’s something real at stake — and when there’s something at stake, people listen. Your resistance is proof you’re close to something meaningful.

“I’m uncomfortable talking about uncomfortable things.”

And yet, the stories that move us most often come from exactly that place. Not because they’re dramatic, but because they’re honest. The uncomfortable is where truth lives — and truth is what your audience will remember.

“I’m a perfectionist.”

But stories aren’t perfect — they’re alive. They twist, stumble, surprise. If you let go of control, just a little, you might find something far more powerful: connection. This class is where precision meets vulnerability.

“Other students’ stories will be better than mine.”

Every person in this room thinks the same thing. But great storytelling isn’t a competition. It’s a discovery — of your voice, your choices, your way of seeing the world. No one else can tell your story the way you can.

“I’ll be judged.”

Of course. We all are, every day — usually in silence. Here, though, people will respond. Not to mock you, but to recognize you. What you fear will isolate you is often the very thing that will create the strongest connection.

Story Reasons (and why this is the place to find out what your story is)

“I don’t have a story.”

You do — you just haven’t looked closely enough. Stories don’t need explosions or headlines. They need a moment where something changed, where what you expected didn’t happen, and you had to make sense of it. That’s enough.

“I have nothing interesting to tell.”

Interesting isn't about scale. It's about truth. A quiet moment, a missed chance, a private realization — if you felt something shift inside you, that's a story worth telling. This class helps you find the shape in the silence.

“My story is not good.”

No story starts fully formed. What you have is raw material. This class helps you find the structure, the center, the moment that matters. The only way your story gets better is by beginning to tell it.

“My story is too long / too short.”

Length is not the issue. Movement is. A story becomes compelling when it travels — from one emotion, one belief, one state to another. Whether that takes 30 seconds or 3 minutes, we’ll help you shape it.

“People might not connect with my story.”

Maybe. Or maybe your story will reach someone you didn't expect — because you dared to tell it. This class isn't about broadcasting. It's about resonance. And you won't know who you'll reach until you try.

“People might not understand my story.”

Then this is your laboratory. If you learn how to shape your story here — for people who think differently, speak differently, come from elsewhere — you’ll carry that skill into every boardroom and every pitch for the rest of your life.

“English is not my first language.”

That makes your voice more distinctive. The cadence, the metaphors, the images you use will often surprise and delight your listeners. Fluency isn't the goal — clarity and impact are.

Where I come from, it's taboo to tell personal stories.”

Then this classroom is rare air. Here, there's no punishment for honesty, no shame in vulnerability. For once, you're allowed to explore what your culture might not — and that exploration is valuable, to you and to us.

“In the context of business, telling stories is unserious.”

In fact, stories are how serious people move others. Metrics explain, logic persuades — but story inspires. In every company, at every level, the people who rise are those who know how to move a room. This class is where you start learning how.

Everything you fear about storytelling — the uncertainty, the exposure, the pressure — that's exactly what makes it powerful.

You're not here to rehearse your polish. You're here to discover your voice.

This class isn't a detour from business.
It's the missing tool that makes everything else click.

The stakes are low. The impact is high.
This isn't just a place to tell stories.

It's a place to find one. Yours.

But this cannot be over-stated:

In this course you get

a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity

to experience publicly telling your story in a

supportive, judgement-free environment

After a break,
we're going to talk about the
gap between story and reality...

BREAK

July 27, 2004

An up-and-coming senate hopeful from Illinois enters the national stage, thanks to a keynote speech at the 2004 Democratic National Convention in Boston (leading up to the 2004 election).

JULY 27, 2004



©CBS NEWS ARCHIVES

The day after

The New York Times

The Nation; An Appeal Beyond Race

 Share full article





By Scott L. Malcomson
Aug. 1, 2004

ON Tuesday, at about 9 p.m., Barack Obama was an Illinois state legislator running for the Senate.

A half-hour later, after he had given the keynote address at the Democratic National Convention, he was the party's hot ticket. Pundits even predicted he would be the first black president.

What's the story here?

Tell me the Obama story:

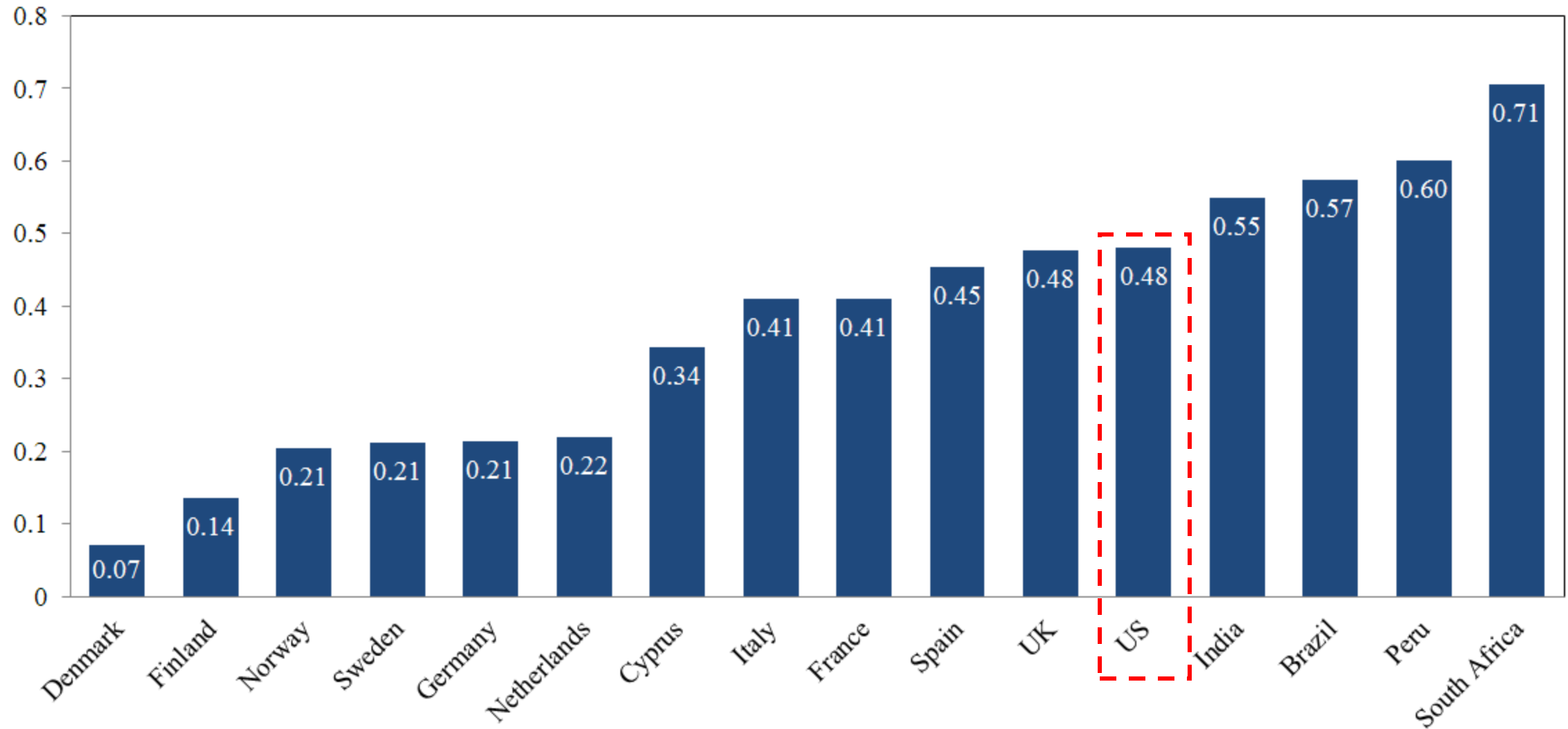
- Just from this clip – no partisan politics, please
- What is the story here?
- Was this story effective?
- If so, why was it effective?

So, in two words,
What is Obama's story?

What is
the American Dream, anyway?

What is the reality?

Intergenerational Income Elasticity

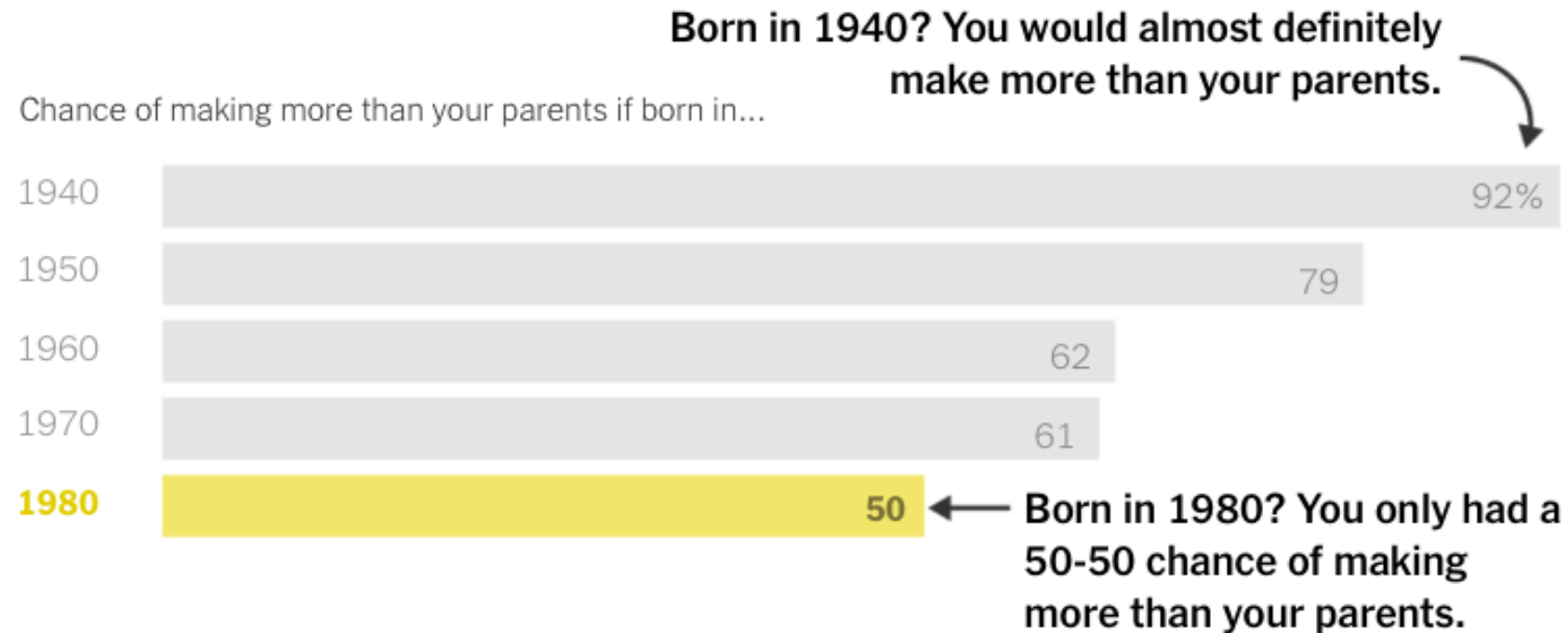


Source: *Inequality of opportunity, income inequality and economic mobility : some international comparisons*, World Bank Report (2013)

Probability of someone born poor becoming rich*



Source: Raj Chetty | *Chance someone born in lowest-earning fifth of households makes it to the top-earning fifth.



Source: "The Fading American Dream: Trends in Absolute Income Mobility Since 1940" (See notes)

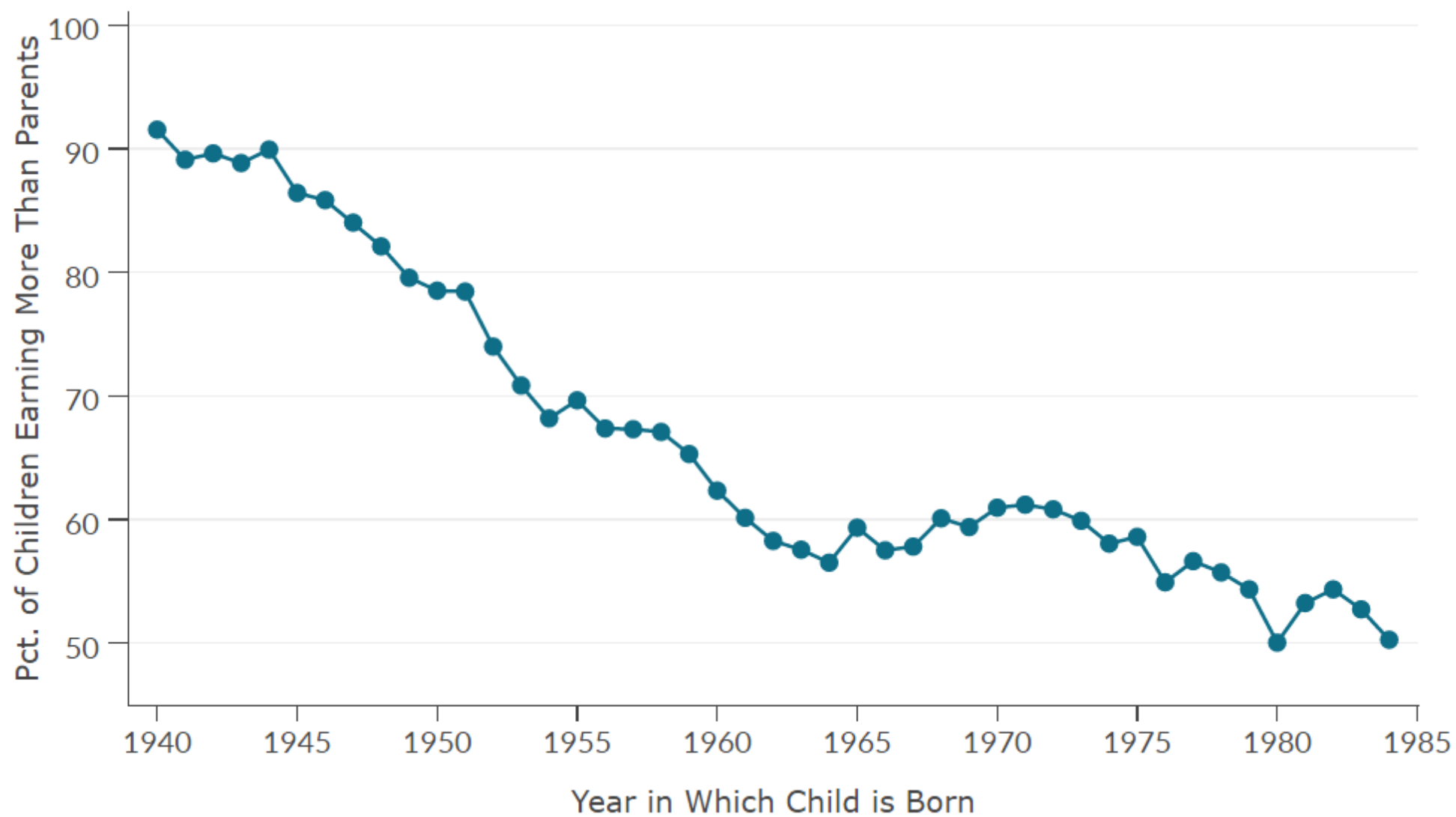


Figure 2. The actual United States wealth distribution plotted against the estimated and ideal distributions across all respondents.

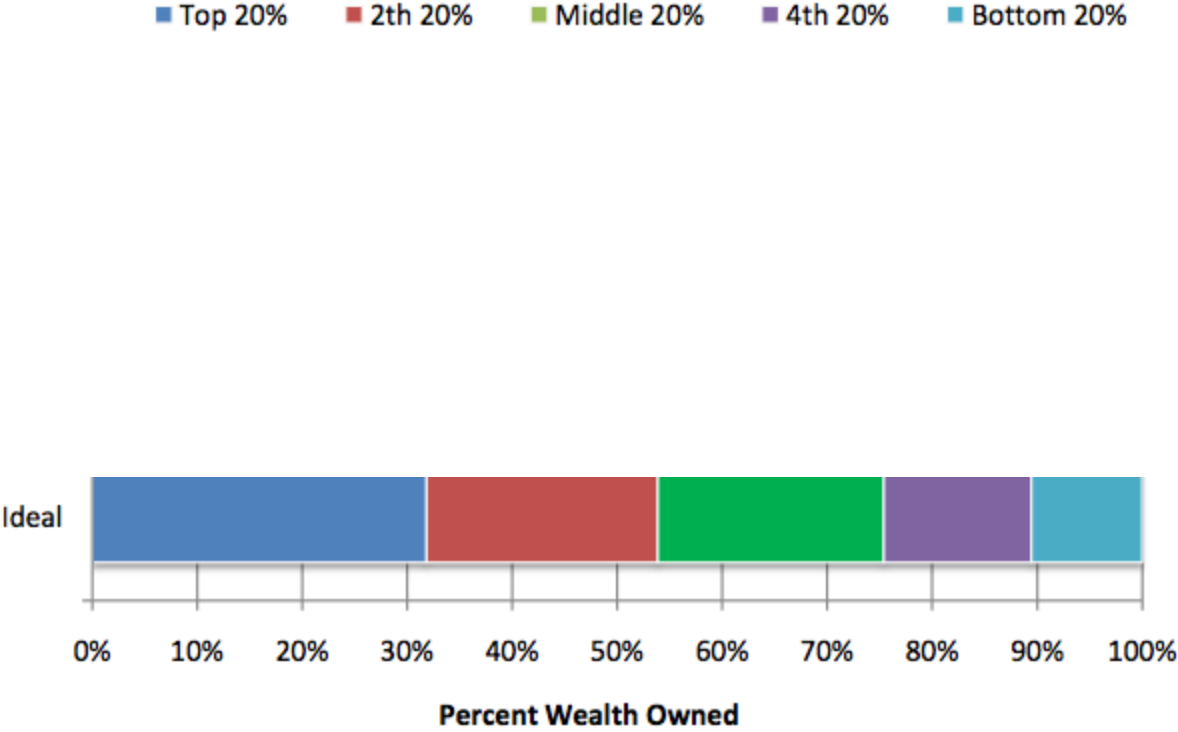


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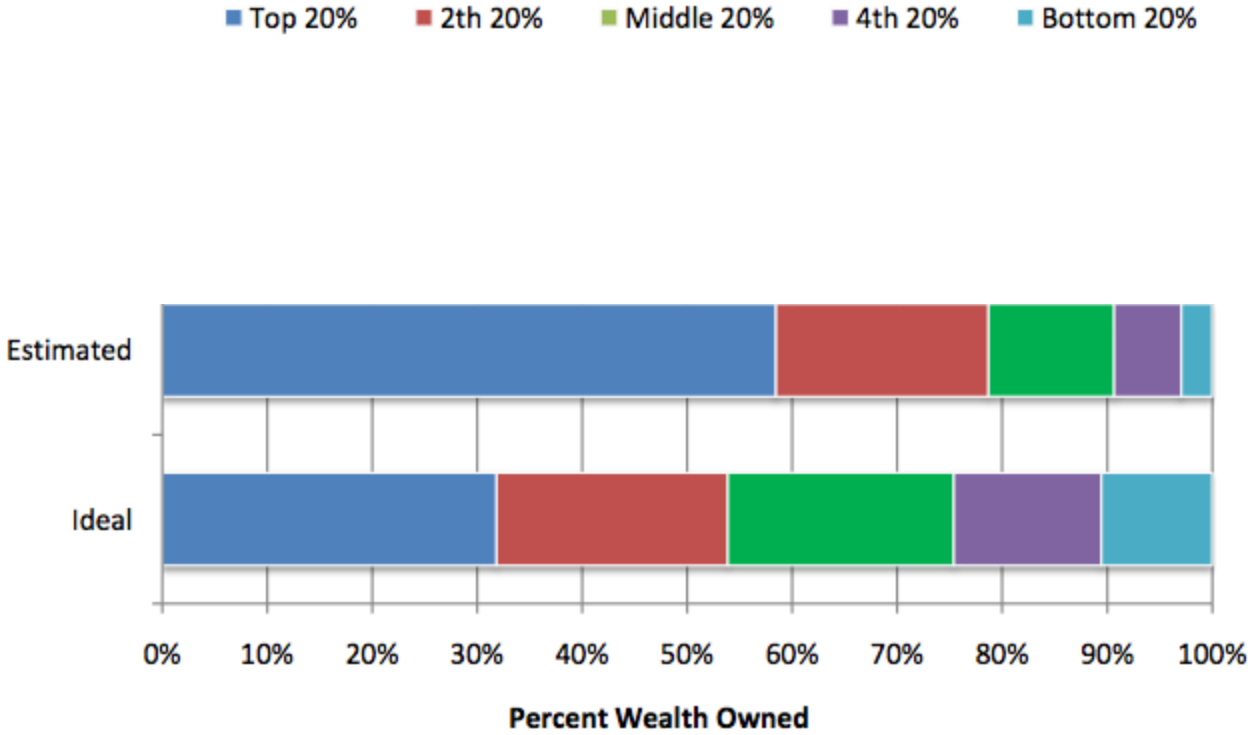
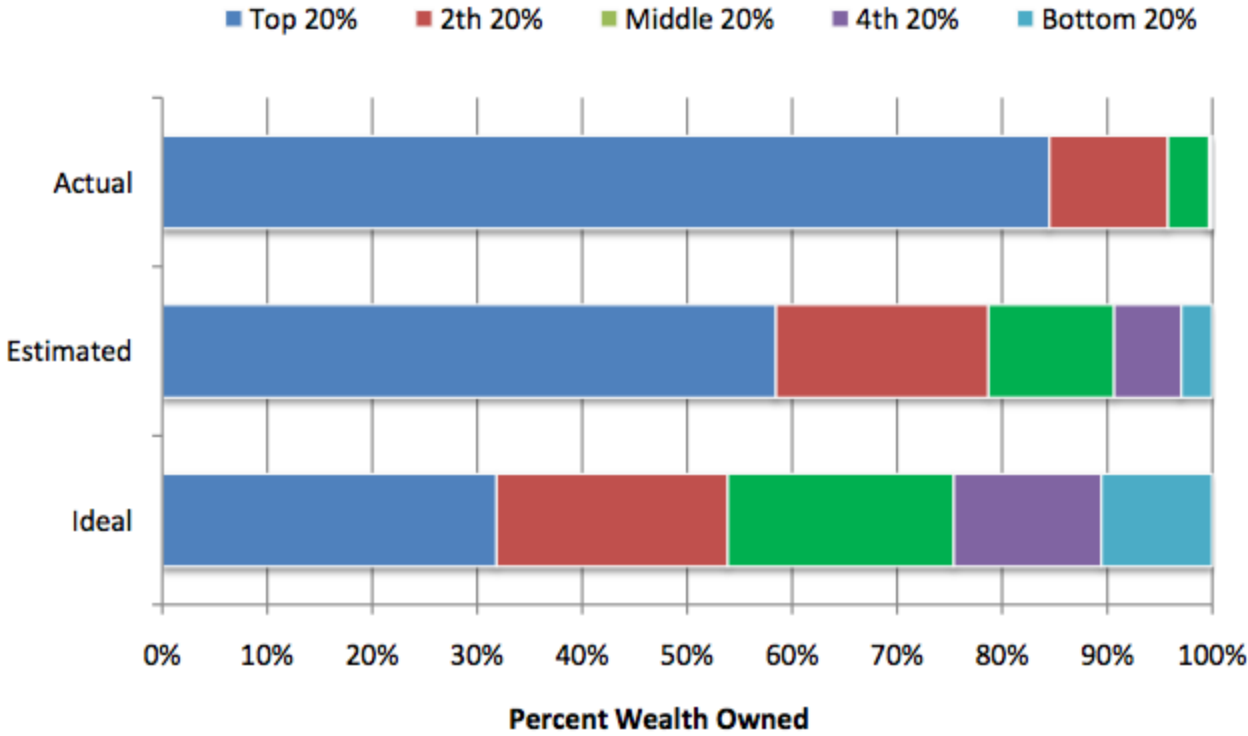


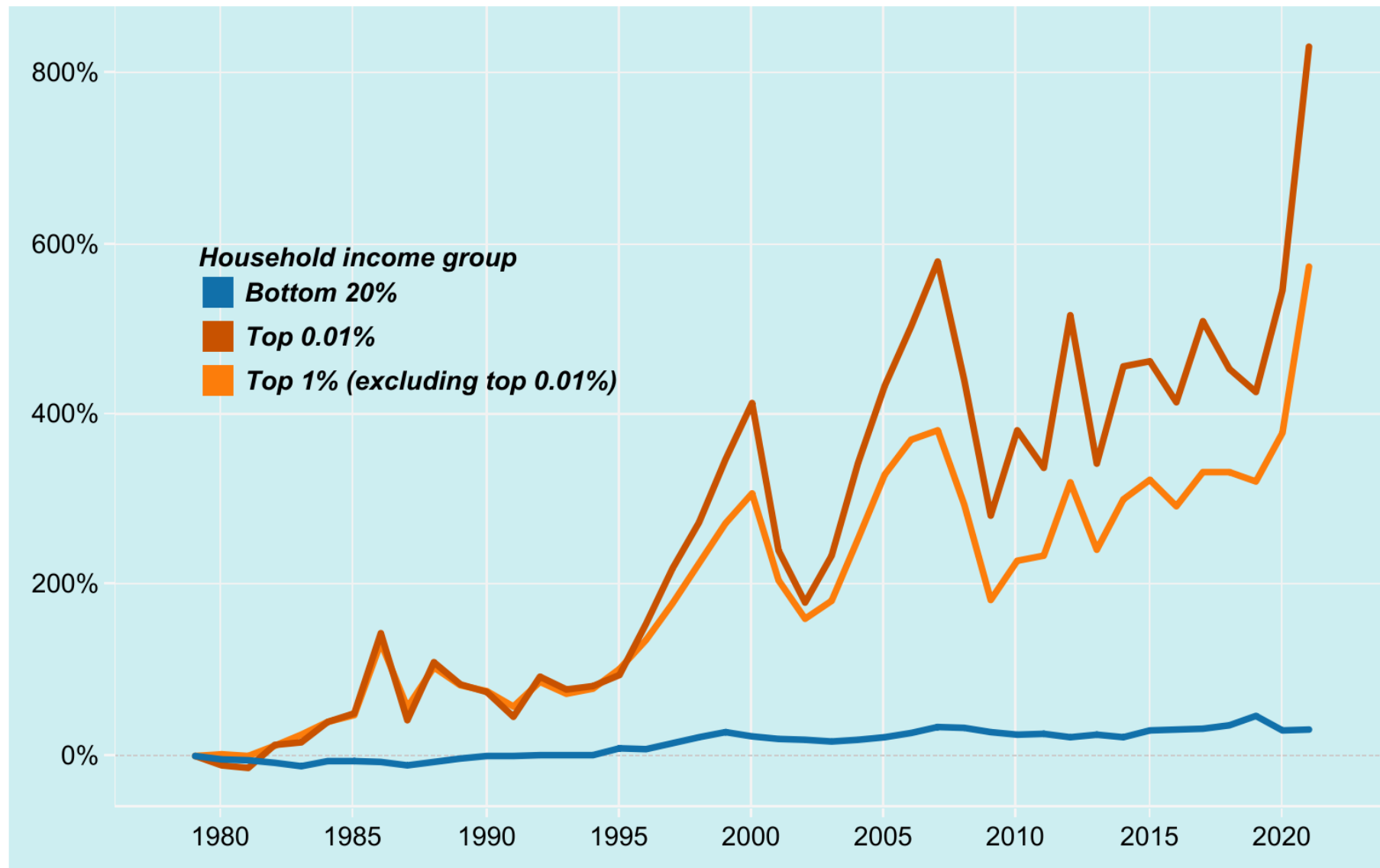
Figure 2. The actual United States wealth distribution plotted against the estimated and ideal distributions across all respondents.



What story does the graph
tell us?

Average Incomes for the Richest Americans Have Skyrocketed

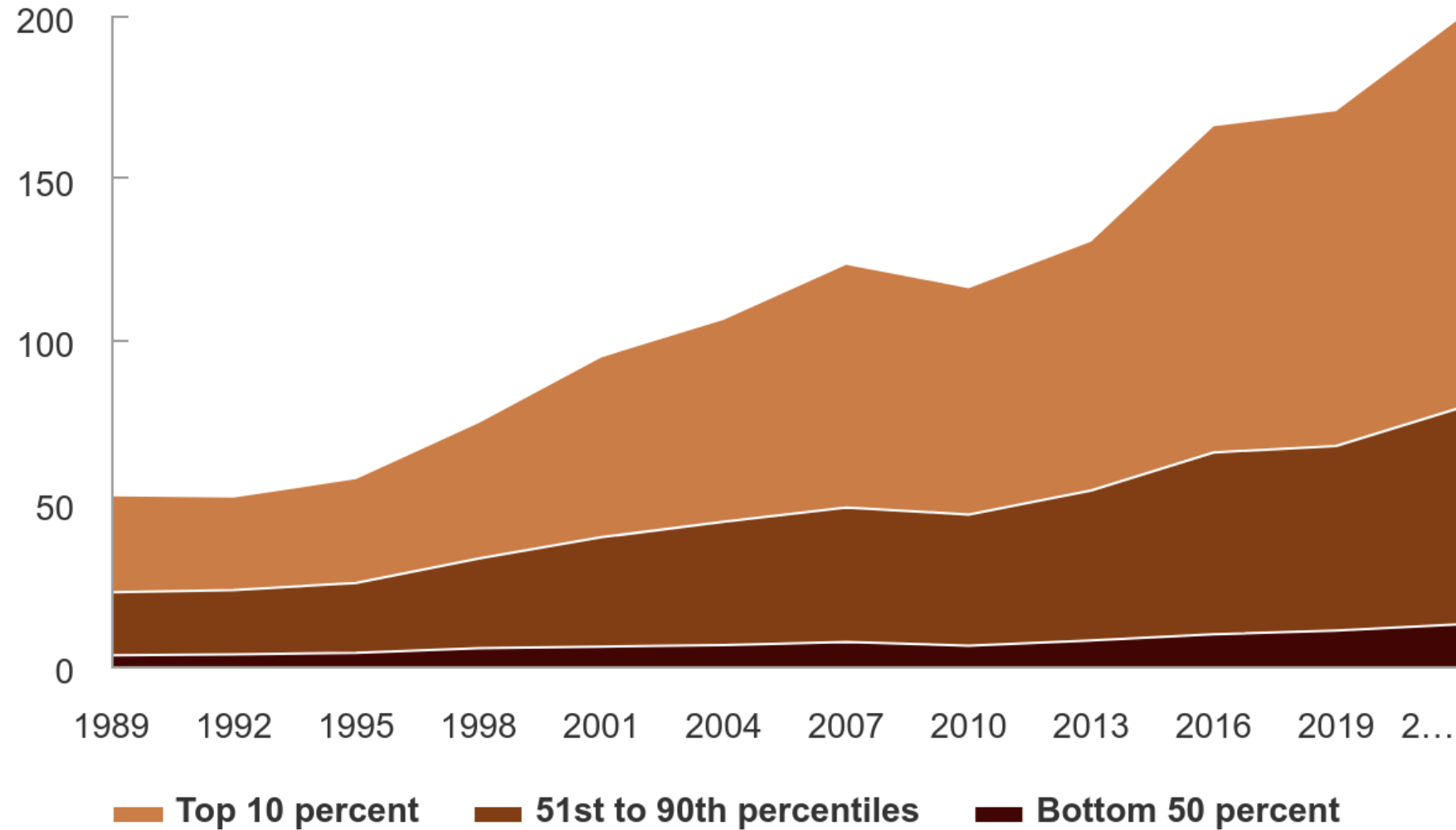
Cumulative growth in U.S. household income before taxes and public assistance, 1979-2021



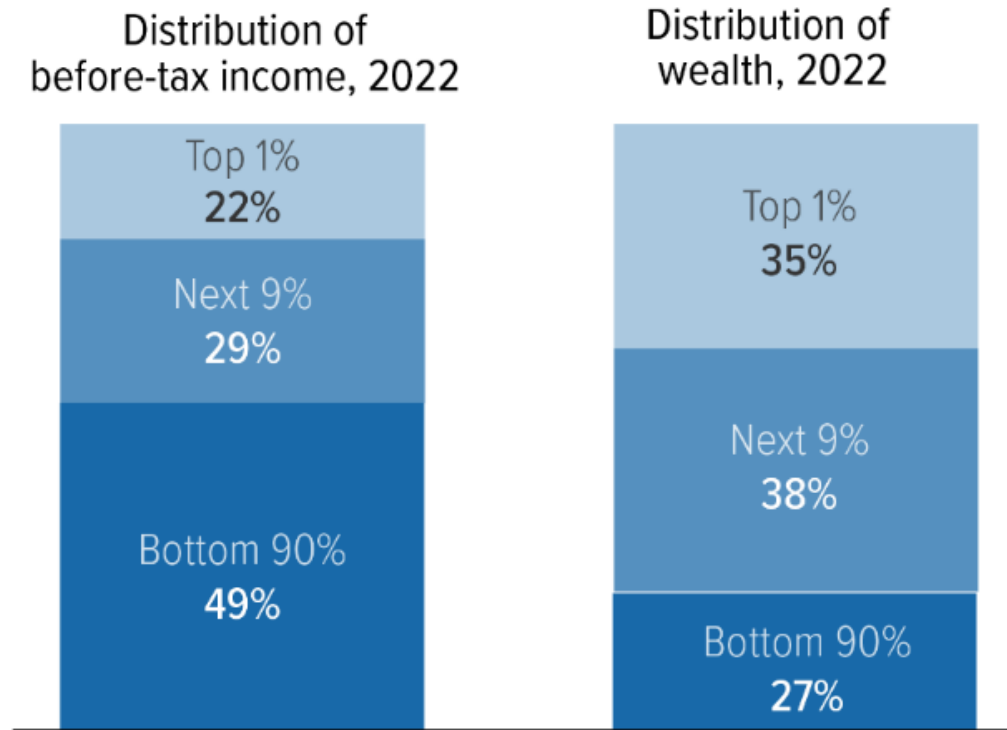
Source: Congressional Budget Office

Total Family Wealth, by Wealth Group

Trillions of 2022 dollars



Wealth Is Even More Concentrated Than Income



Source: CBPP Analysis of the Federal Reserve's Survey of Consumer Finances 2022

CENTER ON BUDGET AND POLICY PRIORITIES | CBPP.ORG

Here's another famous storyteller

This time from the business realm

July 29, 2020

Jeff Bezos's first-ever testimony before Congress took place at a hearing of the House Judiciary Committee, as part of its investigation into Big Tech's market dominance and treatment of competitors.

Bezos the Storyteller—Why It Fell Flat in Congress

- Bezos opened the July 2020 hearing with his classic Amazon garage origin story.
- But the hearing wasn't about beginnings—it was about power, dominance, and harm.
- His story felt tone-deaf, misaligned, and outdated.

Five Reasons It Didn't Land

1. Wrong story for the moment – Congress wanted accountability, not inspiration.
2. Misread the audience – Lawmakers and the public weren't there to admire him.
3. Power flips the narrative – A billionaire founder invoking struggle looks evasive.
4. Weak medium – Zoom hearings flatten emotion; his calm delivery felt aloof.
5. No narrative tension – The story was too familiar, with no new stakes or change.

The Takeaway

- Bezos brought a startup myth to an antitrust interrogation.
- In storytelling, timing and audience matter as much as the message.
- The right story, wrong moment = failure.

How much of our “reality” is
actually constructed by others?

There's no reality, really –
only stories.

Our life is full of battles –
of stories and narratives.
Stories are constantly constructed
around us, battling for a place
in our minds: by politicians and
governments, companies, media,
our bosses, our parents, ourselves...

But what IS a story?

Before we go on, let's define what we mean by "Story"

Some definitions of “Story”

- A narrative, either true or fictitious, in prose or verse, designed to interest, amuse, or instruct the hearer or reader
- The plot or succession of incidents constructing a novel, a poem, a play, a film, etc.
- A narration of an incident or a series of events –
e.g., in the life of a person or in the existence of a thing

Our definition of “Story”

A **sequence of events** in a **protagonist's** life that, through the **resolution** of a specific **conflict**, conveys an intended **idea** to a chosen **audience**

Why are stories
so important?

Stories are how we make
meaning of life



A person wearing a blue jacket and jeans stands on a wooden deck at night, pointing a flashlight upwards towards a starry sky. The flashlight beam illuminates the person's back and the wooden planks of the deck. The background features a dark forest of evergreen trees and distant mountains under a deep purple and blue night sky filled with stars. A semi-transparent dark blue rectangular box is overlaid on the upper half of the image, containing the text.

Stories are how we explain
the world, how things work

Stories are how we understand
our place in the world



A photograph of a road intersection with a large metal fork stuck in the ground. The fork is positioned vertically, with its tines pointing upwards. The road is paved and has white lane markings. In the background, there are trees and a yellow diamond-shaped road sign. The text "Stories are how we make decisions – and justify those decisions" is overlaid on the image in a white font.

Stories are how we make decisions –
and justify those decisions



Stories are how we bond
and make friends

Stories are how we date
and fall in love



Stories are how we
create an identity,
how we develop
our sense of self



Stories are how
we convey values

A sculpture of a chicken, created by Guy Rolnik, is the central focus. It is meticulously constructed from numerous pieces of brown eggshells, which are layered to create a realistic texture for the feathers. The chicken is standing on a smooth, grey surface. Scattered around the base of the sculpture are several broken eggshells and small fragments of shell, suggesting a process of construction or a fragile state. The background is a plain, light grey wall, which emphasizes the sculpture and the text overlay. The text "Stories are how we reach common understanding" is written in a clean, white, sans-serif font, centered over a semi-transparent dark grey rectangular area that spans the width of the image.

Stories are how we reach
common understanding

A photograph of a two-story brick building. The word 'UTOPIA' is mounted on the upper part of the facade in large, red, three-dimensional block letters. Below the letters, the wall is covered in various graffiti, including the word 'LOVE' in white and large, abstract orange and brown spray-painted designs. There are three windows on the ground floor, some of which are boarded up or have graffiti on them. A black door is visible on the right side of the ground floor. In the foreground, there is a red fire hydrant and an orange and white striped traffic barrel. The sky is blue with some clouds, and bare trees are visible in the background.

Stories are how we persuade

A close-up of a hand with the index finger pointing towards the text. The background is a sky at sunset or sunrise, with soft clouds and a bright contrail streaking across the lower half of the frame.

Stories are how we
ignite the imagination



Stories are how we incite action

A photograph of an office cubicle. In the foreground, a large, irregular hole has been dug into the floor, revealing a dark, hollow space underneath. A shovel with a wooden handle and a metal head leans against the left side of the cubicle desk. The desk is cluttered with papers, a computer monitor, and other office supplies. A black office chair is positioned in front of the desk. The cubicle walls are a light-colored, textured material. The overall scene suggests a metaphorical 'digging' or uncovering of something hidden beneath the surface of a job.

Stories are how we get a job

A close-up photograph of a person's hand, wearing a white shirt and a red tie, placing a small, light-brown wooden block onto a wall made of similar blocks. The wall is composed of two rows of blocks, with a noticeable gap in the top row where the new block is being placed. The background is blurred, showing more of the person's torso and the wall.

Stories are how we progress
in our career



Stories are who we are

Stories ARE life

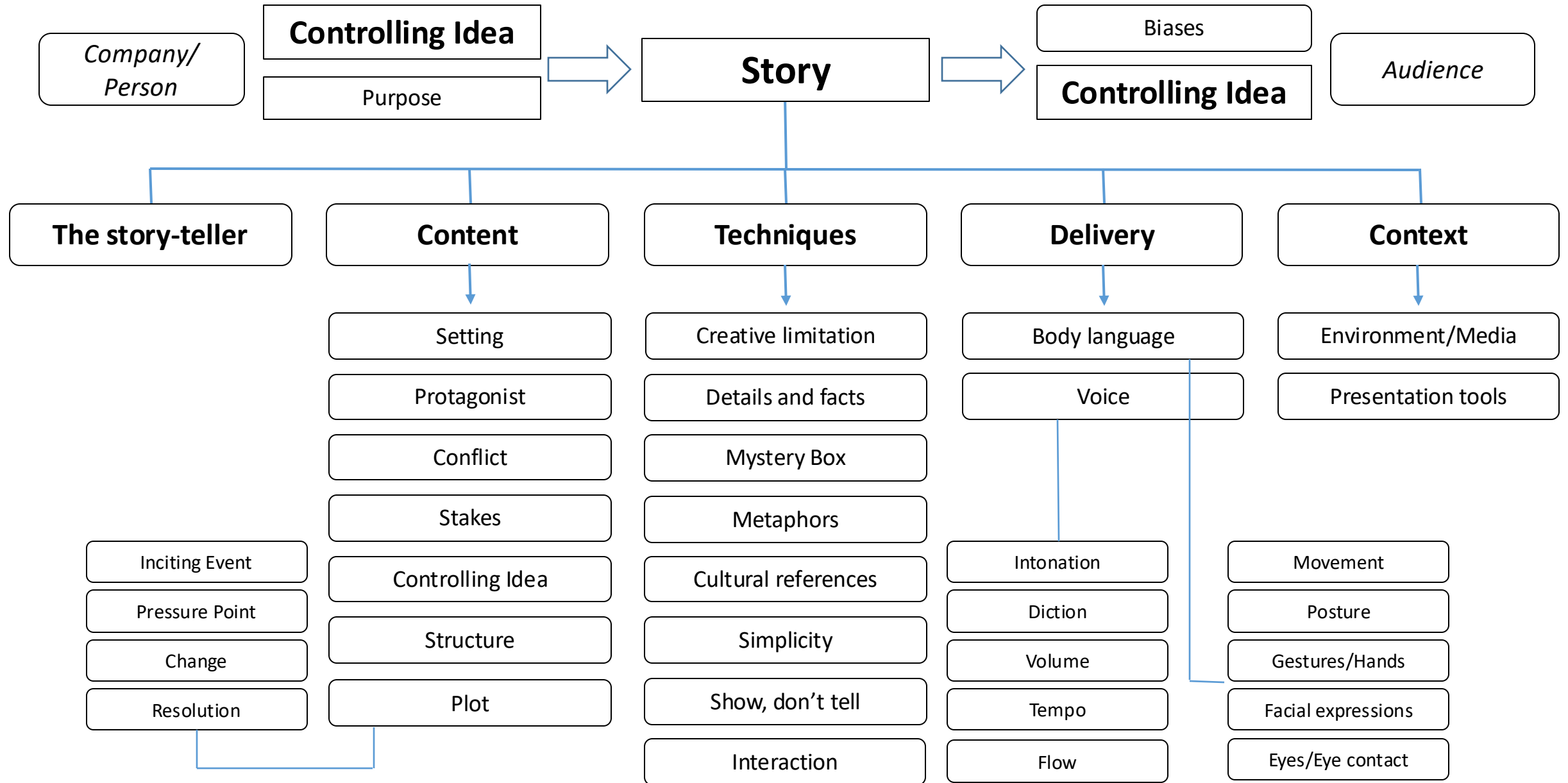
In 2025, in a world that is so
fragmented and fractured,
how do you
break through the clutter?

Do you shout LOUDER?
Do you use data?

Perhaps more than at any time
in the recent past,
storytelling is the answer

So, how do you construct
a great story?

The story model



Our primary tool: The Story Arc Canvas

The Story Arc Canvas

Instructions:

- Use the boxes at the top and on the right to outline the main story elements
- Draw your story's arc
- Use the check boxes on the right as tools to improve your story

☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

Story Headline

Purpose: WIIFM?

The Audience
Who are they?
WIIFT?
Biases

Controlling Idea

Protagonist
Antagonist
Conflict

- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐

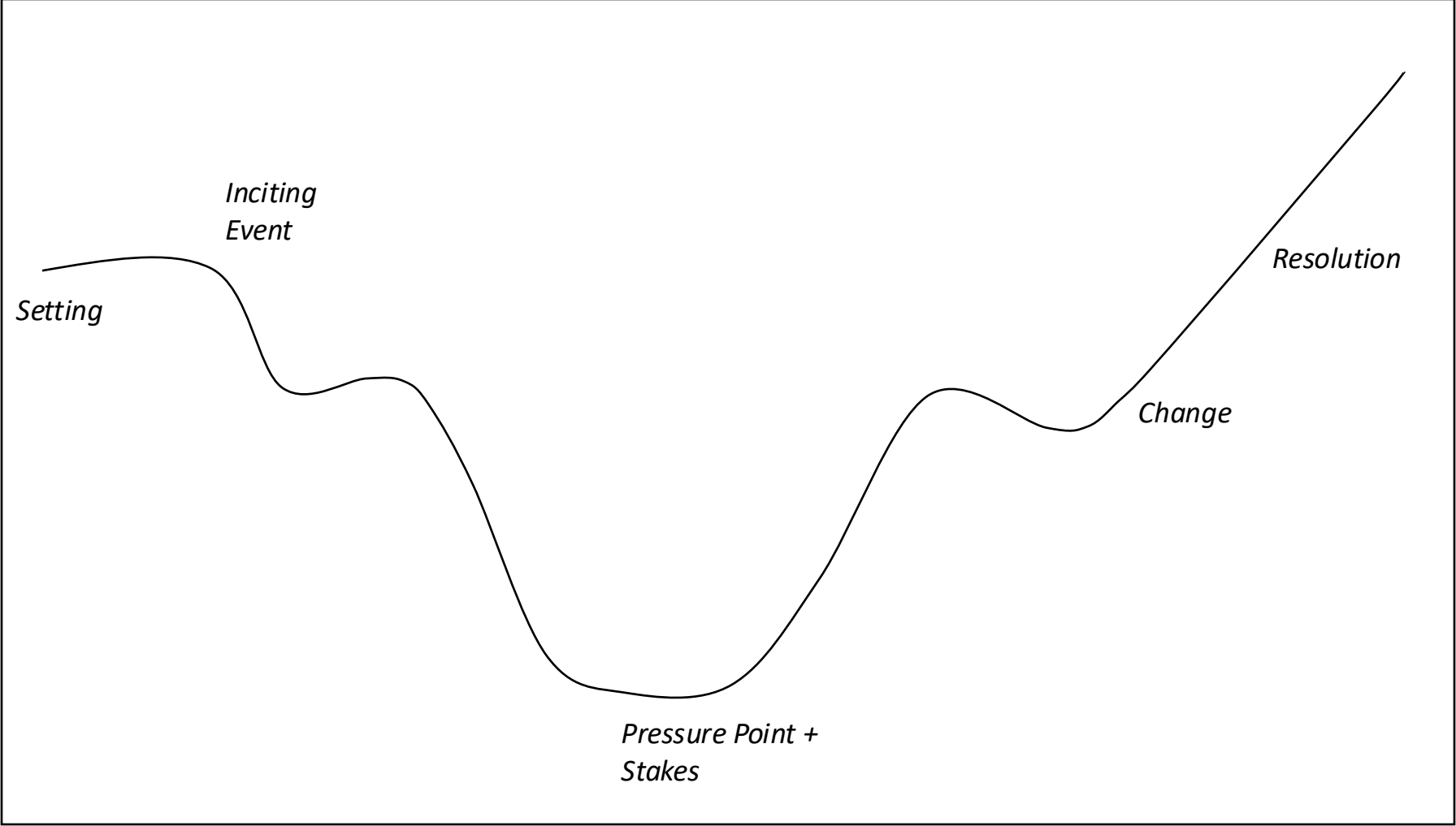
Story Headline

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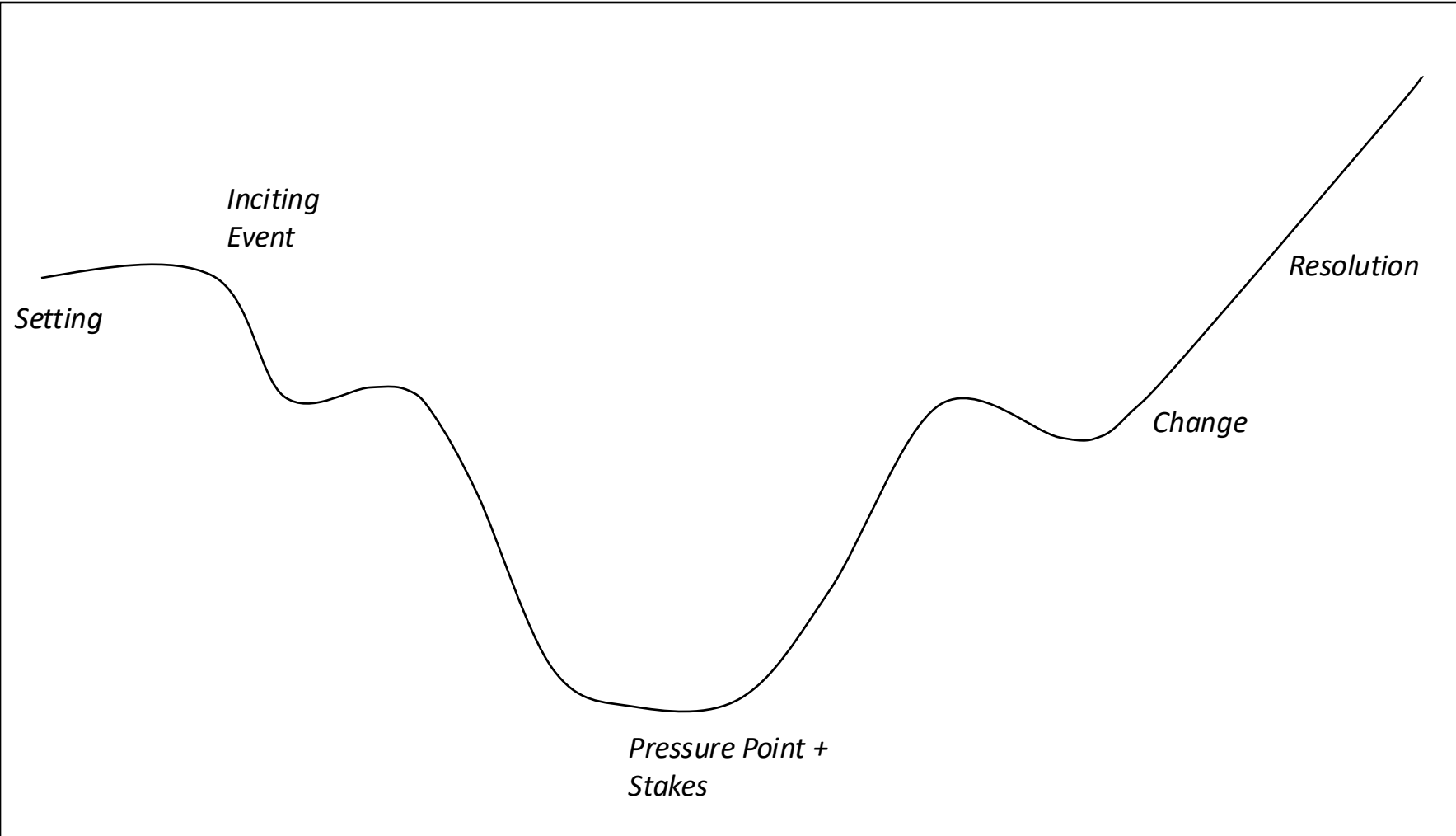
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Creative techniques

- ☐ Limitations
- ☐ Details, facts, anecdotes
- ☐ Mystery Box
- ☐ Metaphors
- ☐ Cultural references
- ☐ Simplicity
- ☐ Show, don't tell
- ☐ Interact

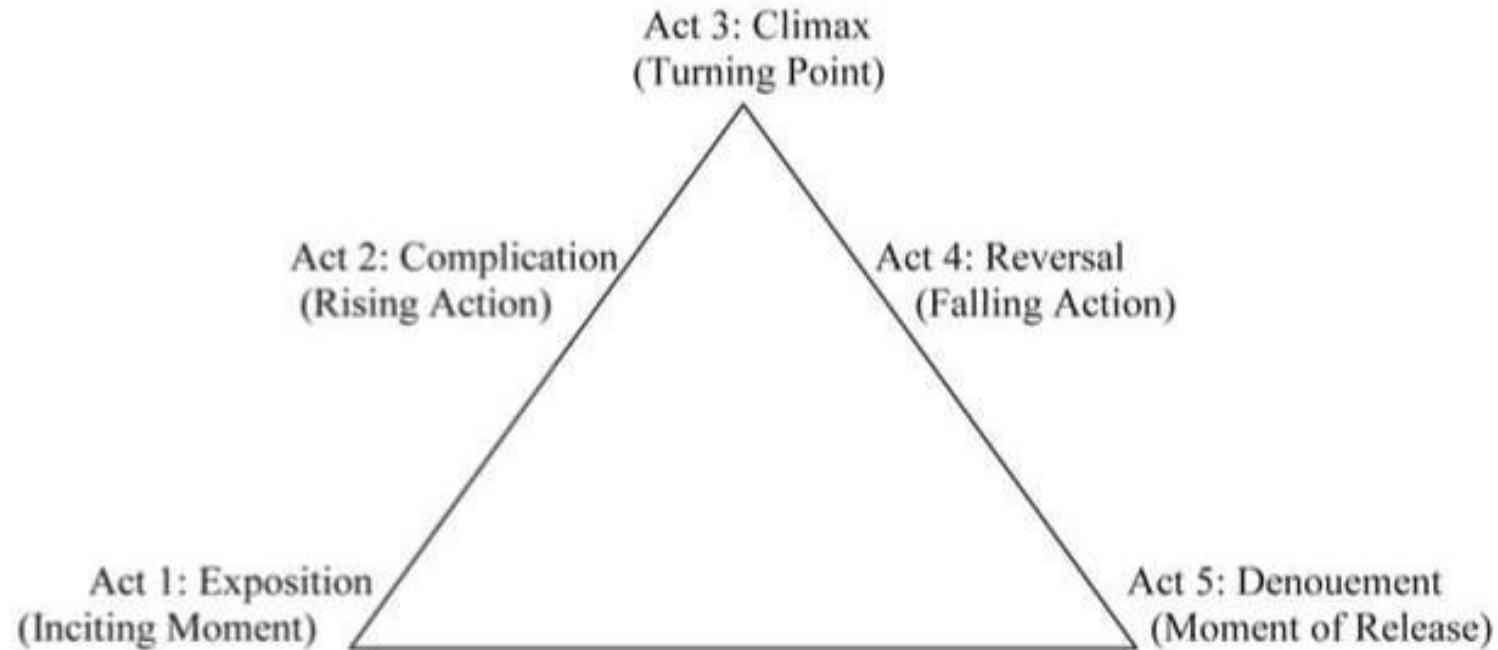
As it turns out, most stories
have a recurring structure –
and only a few basic plots

Structure

Structural principles

- The structure is **a selection of events that form the character's story**, composed into a sequence to arouse specific emotions, and to convey a specific idea
- Structure follows **a cause-and-effect trajectory** from start to finish: no one ever does anything for no reason (although they themselves might not be aware of the reason)
- The structure aims to provide **progressively building pressures** that force characters to make more and more **difficult choices**, revealing their true nature

Freytag's Pyramid



Gustav Freytag, 19th century German novelist and playwright, based his theory of dramatic structure on Aristotle's thinking. He drew this in 1863.

Plot

The Plot

The plot aims to navigate through the dangerous terrain of story, choosing the correct path when confronted by branching possibilities. Simply put, the plot is **the writer's choice of events and their order in time.**

What typical plots
do you know?



Kurt Vonnegut (1922-2007),
an American writer,
considered one of the
20th-century's most important
writers.

Some of his works:
Slaughterhouse-Five,
Cat's Cradle, *Breakfast of
Champions* and others.

Scientists uncover formula for box office movie success

'Man in a hole' story arc - a fall followed by a rise - found to be most commercially successful



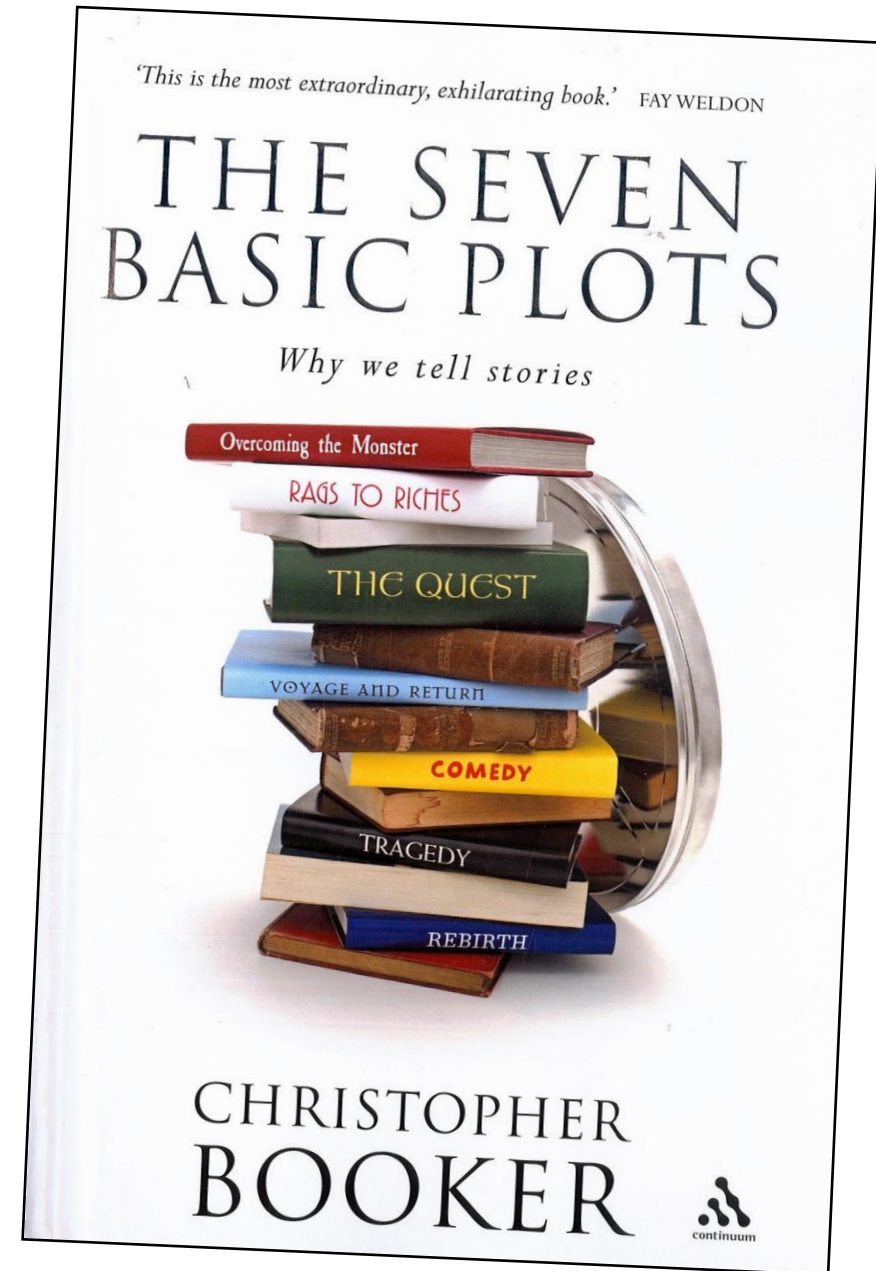
▲ Marlon Brando in The Godfather, an example of a movie with a man in a hole story arc. Photograph: Allstar/Paramount

A team of UK scientists believe they have found the formula for box office success.

After analysing data from 6,147 movie scripts and filtering it through a series of algorithms, the researchers have identified the emotional arc that makes the most money, called the “man in a hole” arc.

The 7 basic plots

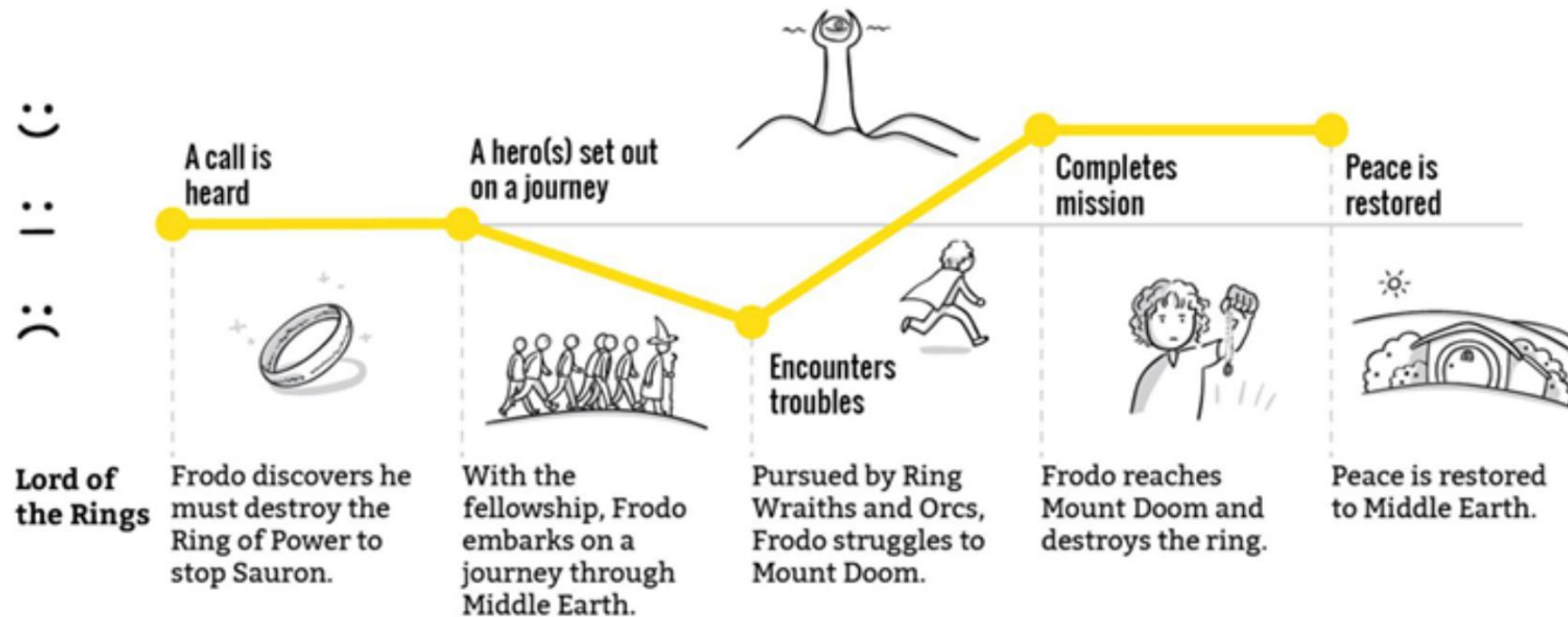
- The Quest
- Overcoming The Monster
- Voyage and Return
- Rags to Riches
- Rebirth
- Comedy
- Tragedy



The Quest

The protagonist and some companions set out to acquire an important object or to get to a location – and achieve a seemingly unachievable goal. Many obstacles and temptations are met along the way.

Examples: *Iliad*, *The Pilgrim's Progress*, *King Solomon's Mines*, *Watership Down*, *The Lord of the Rings*, *Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows*, *The Land Before Time*, *Indiana Jones*, *The Voyage of the Dawn Treader*, *Harold & Kumar Go To White Castle*





From Amazon.toast to Amazoning the competition



1997 Shareholder Letter

To our shareholders:

Amazon.com passed many milestones in 1997: by year-end, we had served more than 1.5 million customers, yielding 838% revenue growth to \$147.8 million, and extended our market leadership despite aggressive competitive entry.

But this is Day 1 for the Internet and, if we execute well, for Amazon.com. Today, online commerce saves customers money and precious time. Tomorrow, through personalization, online commerce will accelerate the very process of discovery. Amazon.com uses the Internet to create real value for its customers and, by doing so, hopes to create an enduring franchise, even in established and large markets.

We have a window of opportunity as larger players marshal the resources to pursue the online opportunity and as customers, new to purchasing online, are receptive to forming new relationships. The competitive landscape has continued to evolve at a fast pace. Many large players have moved online with credible offerings and have devoted substantial energy and resources to building awareness, traffic, and sales. Our goal is to move quickly to solidify and extend our current position while we begin to pursue the online commerce opportunities in other areas. We see substantial opportunity in the large markets we are targeting. This strategy is not without risk: it requires serious investment and crisp execution against established franchise leaders.

It's All About the Long Term

We believe that a fundamental measure of our success will be the shareholder value we create over the *long term*. This value will be a direct result of our ability to extend and solidify our current market leadership position. The stronger our market leadership, the more powerful our economic model. Market leadership can translate directly to higher revenue, higher profitability, greater capital velocity, and correspondingly stronger returns on invested capital.

2023 shareholder letter

There has never been a time in Amazon's history where we've felt there is so much opportunity to make our customers' lives better and easier. We're incredibly excited about what's possible, focused on inventing the future, and look forward to working together to make it so.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, reading "Andy Jassy". The signature is fluid and cursive, with the first name "Andy" and last name "Jassy" clearly distinguishable.

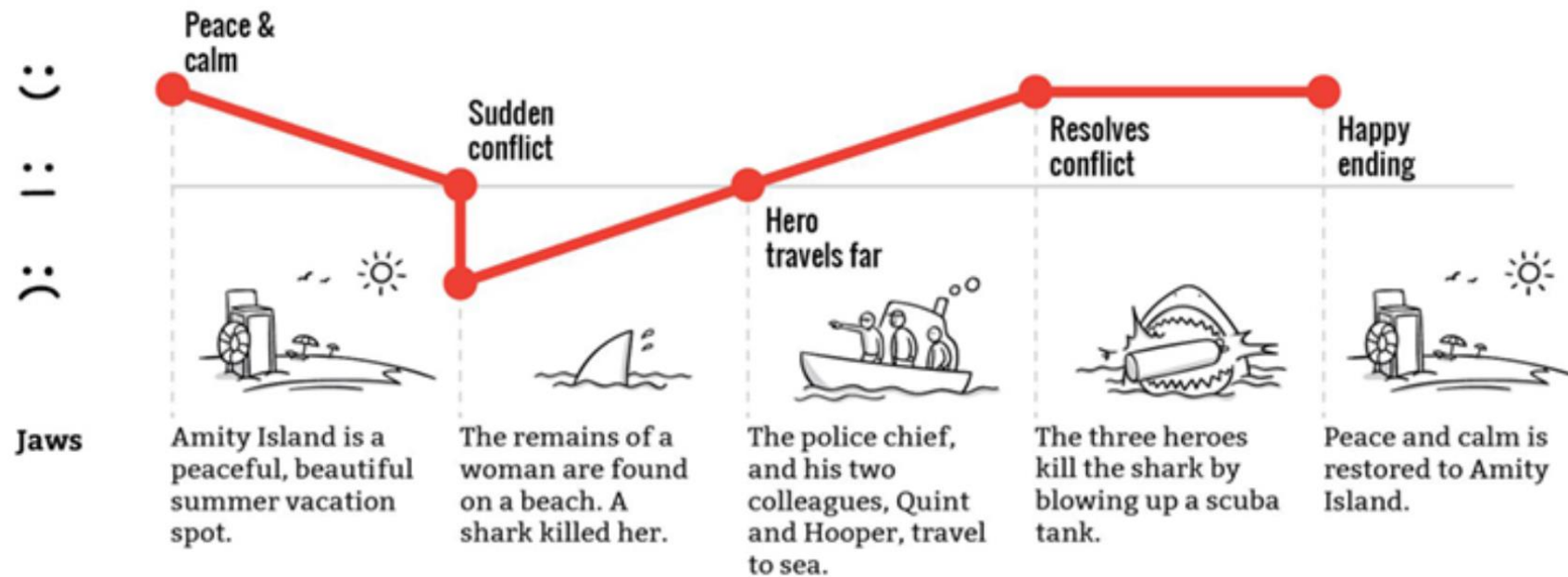
Andy Jassy
President and Chief Executive Officer
Amazon.com, Inc.

P.S. As we have always done, our original 1997 Shareholder Letter follows. What's written there is as true today as it was in 1997.

Overcoming the Monster

The protagonist sets out to defeat an antagonistic force (often evil) which threatens the protagonist.

Examples: *Perseus*, *Theseus*, *Beowulf*, *Dracula*, *The War of the Worlds*, *Nicholas Nickleby*, *The Guns of Navarone*, *Seven Samurai/The Magnificent Seven*, the James Bond franchise, *Star Wars: A New Hope*, *Halloween*, *The Hunger Games*, *Harry Potter* and *Shrek*.





Technology

Bill Gates's Carefully Curated Geek Image Unravels in Two Weeks

Microsoft co-founder's philanthropic legacy is threatened by new revelations about his behavior

By Austin Carr

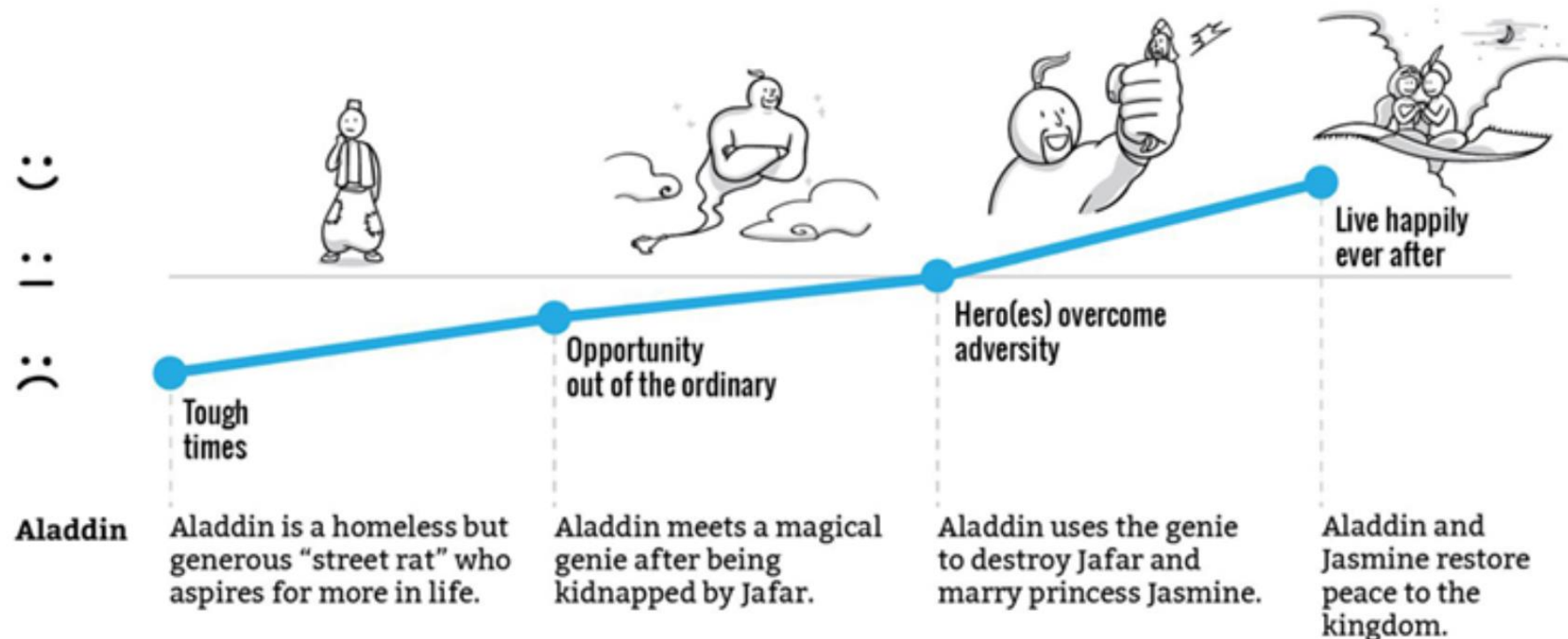
May 21, 2021, 4:00 AM EDT

Before all the revelations about his divorce, dubious workplace behavior and ties to Jeffrey Epstein, Bill Gates was just America's huggable billionaire techno-philanthropist. Sure, he had accumulated absurd riches from cofounding Microsoft Corp. and lived in a \$130 million mansion with an indoor trampoline room. But he was also known to drive his kids to school, binge *Modern Family*, dress like Ned Flanders and wait in line for his favorite cheeseburgers.

Rags to Riches

The poor protagonist acquires things such as power, wealth, and a mate, before (often) losing it all and gaining it back upon growing as a person.

Examples: *Job*, *Cinderella*, *Aladdin*, *Jane Eyre*, *A Little Princess*, *Great Expectations*, *David Copperfield*, *The Prince and the Pauper*, *Brewster's Millions*.

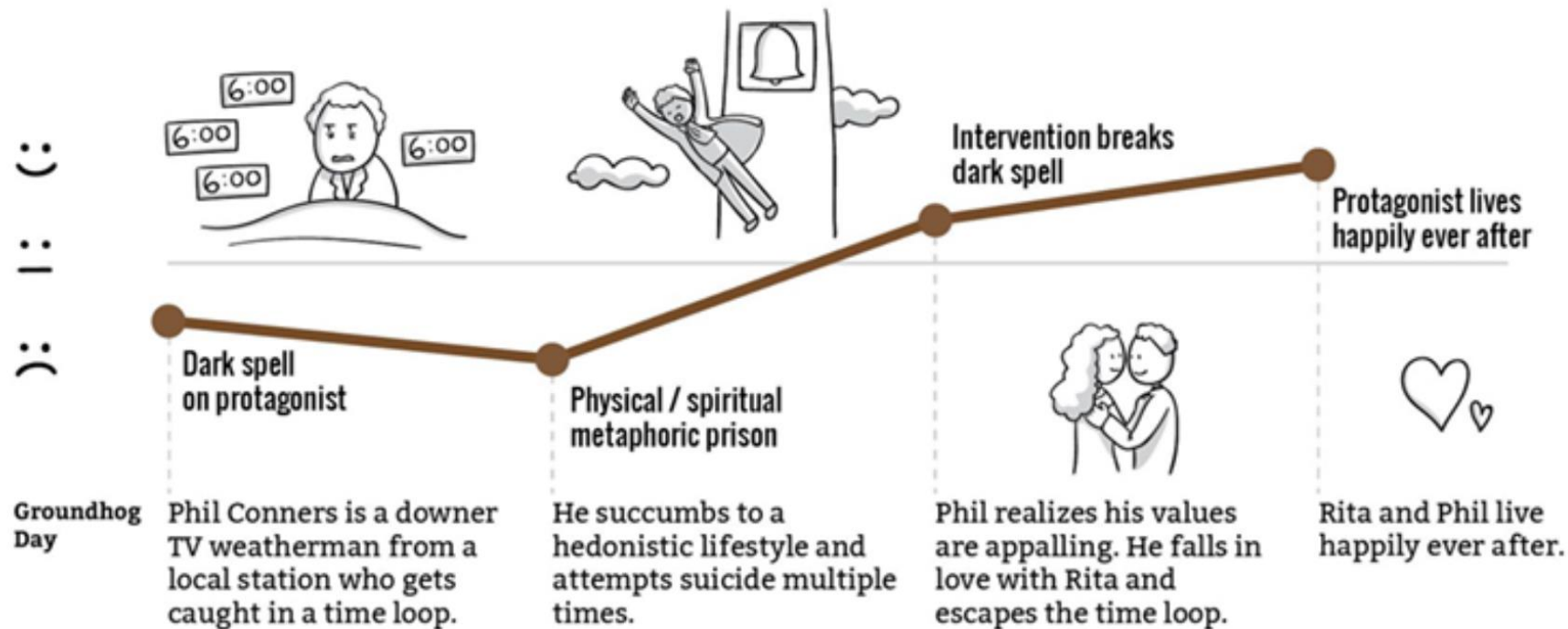




Rebirth

During the course of the story, an important event forces the main character to change their ways, often making them a better person; often, a literal or figurative near-death situation is the genesis of positive change.

Examples: *The Frog Prince*, *Beauty and the Beast*, *The Snow Queen*, *A Christmas Carol*, *The Secret Garden*, *Peer Gynt*, *Despicable Me*, *Megamind*, *How the Grinch Stole Christmas*.





PERSON^{OF}THE YEAR

TIME

—
DONALD
TRUMP
—



The difference between Structure and Plot

- The Plot describes **the events** of the story. The Structure is **the order** in which they're presented
- Put a but differently: The Plot is **What happens**. The Structure is **How it's organized**

Summary so far

- Reality is made of stories
- What IS a story
 - A **sequence of events** in a **protagonist's** life that, through the **resolution** of a specific **conflict**, conveys an intended **idea** to a chosen **audience**
- The importance of stories
 - Stories are life
- The Story Arc Canvas
- There is one structure and plot

In essence, we have told one another the same tale,
one way or another, since the dawn of humanity:

Essentially, a story... begins with a situation
in which life is relatively **in balance**...

But then there's an event – ...the “**inciting incident**” –
that throws life **out of balance**...

In an effort to **restore balance**... the protagonist [has]
to dig deeper... make difficult decisions,
take action despite risks, and **ultimately discover the truth**.

Robert McKee

BREAK

Roni Frank

Roni Frank is the co-founder of Talkspace, the leading virtual behavioral health company, where she served as Head of Clinical Services, overseeing a network of over 3,000 licensed therapists. Under her leadership, Talkspace expanded global access to affordable, high-quality mental health care.

In January 2021, Talkspace announced its planned \$1.4 billion merger with Hudson Executive Investment Corp., and officially became a publicly traded company on June 23, 2021 (NASDAQ: TALK), becoming the only pure-play virtual behavioral health company on the public market.

Prior to founding Talkspace in 2012, Roni worked as a software developer at Amdocs.



Thank you, Roni!